

Labs to come up

Government of India has planned to set up some labs in India to support the growth of the electronic system design and manufacturing (ESDM) industry at a CAGR of 9.9 per cent. In view of this, the Department of Electronics and Information Technology (DeitY) has been proposed to invest ₹ 650,000 million in the area of manufacturing of electronics and semiconductors. Thus the first lab on semiconductor characterisation in India is expected to be set up in Bengaluru in the next six months, the success of which would lead to the set up of another lab in Bhubaneswar that is expected to be launched in next one year.

A report on Karnataka ESDM policy suggests that the government has decided to set up three ESDM innovation centres within Karnataka. The main idea behind these centres is to provide facilities for testing and development, to have characterisation labs, and compliance and certifications labs. The first amongst these would be housed at IIT Bengaluru.

Another report by India Electronics and Semiconductor Association (IESA) suggests that BIS is to set up a test lab in Khurda cluster to help the preferential access to the products that are manufactured in India.

schemes. There are regular trainings for the manpower working in the labs to ensure their awareness of latest developments on international platforms. BIS is training officers from its own labs on international standards like IS/ISO/IEC 17025 and is also providing summer training to the students from different universities and colleges on the laboratory-related works.

BIS has also come up with the Laboratory Recognition Scheme (LRS) that helps the outside laboratories (OSLs) to get recognition. These OSLs are the ones that help labs like BIS with testing facilities during situations such as a large number of samples for testing, or BIS testing equipment being out of order. In order to support this scheme, about seven OSLs have been recognised in the year 2012-13 to test products covered under electronics and information technology goods, such as IT (IS 13252), AV (IS 616) and microwave ovens (IS 302-2-25).

C.S. Bisht, scientist 'G' and senior director, IT Centre, STQC Delhi says, "STQC has come up with the scheme for approval of IT test laboratories (ITTLs) for software solutions. STQC will be the nodal agency managing this approval scheme. The scheme requires ITTLs to implement a domain-specific laboratory 'Quality Management System' based on ISO/IEC 17025 standard. The IT test laboratory will be assessed as per ISO/IEC 17025 general requirements for the competence of testing and calibration laboratories. ITTLs will also be assessed as per ISO/IEC 25051 (ISO/IEC 29119 under development) for test management activities. STQC approval body (ITTL) will operate as per ISO/IEC 17011: 2004 standard 'Conformity Assessment-General requirement for accreditation bodies accrediting conformity assessment bodies'."

Vamshi adds, "There are a number of OSLs in India presently that cannot be compared to the giant service and solution providers, though they have their own value and their existence here is important as per the requirements." ●

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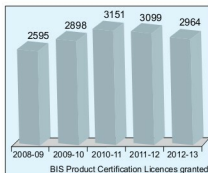


Fig. 5: Product certificate licences (Courtesy: BIS)

policies and incentives from the government. Otherwise, it becomes very difficult for the industry to come forward and take the initiative or to make the first move.

Consider a situation where there is a small change in standards by BIS and the private test labs have not been informed about it in time. They may have tested 500 products by the time the new standard is announced. Now what should the test labs do with the 500 test reports? There would be extra time and manpower required to test according to the new standards for the

correct certification.

Gupta explains, "Over the last few months there have been several requests pertaining to certified components, power supply and power cords. These requirements have not been restricted to just UL but were also applicable to other private, ERTL or government labs, with instances where reports have had to be withdrawn and revised accordingly."

Solutions implemented

The manufacturing sector is taking steps to see that they adopt sustainable practices. The labs now ensure that their services are not limited to testing but they also support the manufacturers for proper systems implementation. The labs are also ensuring that the manufacturers follow proper social compliance standards and maintain certain occupational safety in their work premises.

As per a report by BIS, they are taking certain basic measures to ensure the growth of the labs and the certification industry, which includes training and the labs' recognition